

Finding Mentors & Sponsors

Building support to move forward, when you start out isolated

4 psychology approaches · tips & advice — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Building support to move forward, when you start out isolated

To advance, talent isn't enough: you need to be seen, supported, recommended. Yet as a Black or racialized woman, you often have less access to mentors — and especially sponsors, the people who speak about you when you're not in the room.

This guide helps you understand the mentor/sponsor difference, dare to ask, and build a support network that opens doors.

Your intention

A person or network that could support you: _____

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

What stops you from asking

'I should manage alone', the fear of bothering or of 'owing something': these reflexes often come from an inheritance of self-sufficiency, sometimes reinforced by having had to carry everything alone.

Asking for support isn't an admission of weakness: it's a strategy everyone uses.

Example

Raised to 'rely only on herself', Aïcha didn't dare ask for any support. Understanding the reflex helped her open up.

What holds me back from asking

What stops me from asking for support? Where does the reflex come from?

What isolation costs me

List what not being supported/recommended may have cost you.

→ *Asking for support isn't weakness — it's a strategy.*

The thoughts that isolate

'No one will want to help me', 'I have nothing to offer in return', 'I'll be a bother'. These thoughts stop you from reaching out.

Testing them (with a small ask) often disproves them.

Example

Sure they'd 'have no time for her', Nia dared to ask a senior for a coffee. She gladly said yes.

Thought journal

Note: the thought that holds me back · a fairer version.

The small test

Pick ONE small ask to dare this week (advice, a coffee).

→ *People help more readily than I believe.*

Allowing yourself to be supported

You deserve to be guided, advised, championed — as much as anyone. Receiving support takes nothing from your worth: it reveals it.

Building support is part of success, not beside it.

Example

Léa stopped believing that accepting help was 'cheating'. Building support sped up her progress.

What I allow myself to receive

Write what you allow yourself to ask for (advice, an intro, a recommendation).

My value to share

What can YOU offer in return (perspective, energy, skill)?

→ *I deserve support — building it is part of my success.*

Building mentors & sponsors

A mentor advises you; a sponsor speaks about you and recommends you in high places — they open the doors. Identify them, approach with a precise ask, make your work visible, maintain the relationship, and give back.

Networks of Black/racialized women are a goldmine of mentors and allies.

Example

By making her wins visible to a supportive leader, Fatou turned her into a sponsor: she recommended her for a promotion.

My mapping

Note: 1 potential mentor · 1 potential sponsor · 1 network to join.

My first approach

Write the precise, modest ask you'll dare (and what you'll make visible).

→ *Mentor advises, sponsor recommends — and the sponsor opens doors.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- Tell mentor (advises you) from sponsor (recommends/champions you in your absence).
- Identify 2-3 people; approach with a precise, modest ask.
- Make your work visible to them (wins, projects).
- Maintain the relationship (regular updates, thanks).
- Join networks of Black/racialized women in your field.
- Give back: 'pay it forward', help others in turn.

To fill in

My support mapping

Person / network	Mentor or sponsor?	Next action

My asks

To whom	My precise ask

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — Understand what stops me from asking.

Week 2 — Disprove the thoughts that isolate.

Week 3 — Allow myself to be supported.

Week 4 — Approach mentors & sponsors.

Your plan in 3 lines

- My potential mentor:
- My potential sponsor:
- My first ask:

TO CLOSE

You deserve support — the network is built, one bond at a time.

You deserve support. The network is built.

This guide is a coaching and psychoeducation tool, not a substitute for therapy. If you are going through a hard time, please reach out to a professional or a crisis line in your country. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.